

Codes for (Un)Raveling

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I like words for how they feel, and so this new feeling, this new feeding is perfect for me.

This new trend for language generating? It's poetry to me. Poetry that takes 600 transatlantic flights to generate.

"Large language models" roll off the tongue don't they? They lay waste. They are languid. They loll. Or is it LOL? (spelt l-o-l).

I won't know until it pronounces for me. Until it pronounces me. Pronounces me whole and I can't interrupt it. I yield to their language.

AI mouths my language for me, this language that was never mine. It mined me for something. It had me. It made me. Made me bend. It unmade me, unmouthed me.

“They say, the language you speak is made up of words that are killing you.”
(Wittig, 1971)

When the term “underfitting” autocorrects to undercutting, this is undermining.

The mechanical speaker reads so literally. It knows only one way to interpret:

“Testing one thousand, two hundred, thirty four. Testing one thousand, two hundred, thirty four.”

“Persevering face emoji. Persevering face emoji. Persevering face emoji. Persevering face emoji”

The way its over-correctness slips into error is an erotics.

When I imagine myself as a large language model, I start all my replies with, “As a Large Language Model,...”

“As a Large Language Model, my responses are based on patterns and probabilities learned from the vast amounts of text data I was trained on.”

I know these systems are coming for us. I suspect there is no stopping them.

I say ‘them’ like the systems are separate, like we didn’t make them from our language, our mouths.

“Not one of them: Using words like race seems to amplify what makes you not fit, picking up what you are not. Perhaps a not is heard as shouting, as insistence, a stress point, a sore point, an exclamation point.” (Ahmed, 2018)

System operations are called sometimes called threads. *“A thread of execution is the smallest sequence of programmed instructions that can be managed independently.”* Threads distribute resources and allocate energy.

A thread starts small, jots down, casts a line. It traces connections and tracks versions. It unties the notion of one authoritative text. A ribbon was once

called a notion — a decorative flourish, a small domestic thing. To thread the needle is to pinpoint one's argument or to split the difference.

Threads are ligatures, they sew up the spaces between, tie meaning tightly, linking letters. Threads are sutures. In one death ritual a ball of thread is unwound and passed around a body. Each mourner ties the thread to their wrist until everyone is connected in a network of grief. When the threads between them are snipped, the loops stay tied around their wrists. The strings go threadbare then fall off. Grief wears away.

Used to be, you'd knot a string around your finger if you had something to remember. The digit might turn red, then purple, but eventually you'd recall. Now to remember, speak into your device.

Some things I cannot fathom. There are 36,672 stitches in the crocheted labyrinth I made. It took months.

The GPT-3 model has 175 billion connections in its neural network. That is almost 5 million labyrinths, taking almost a million years to crochet.

Sure, it's better at telling me what I want to hear.

As a Large Language Model, I must emphasize the importance of sensitivity and ethical considerations.

But FUCK the size of these systems when their approach is so cruel. After so many stitches, still they cannot muster kinder, more expansive patterns of language about Black people, about trans people, about queer people?!

Code loops allow actions to repeat. They form muscle memories. They say return to the same spot, and act again. They say remember what you did.

Crochet is made of loops, in lieu of knots. It is the one fiber art that machines cannot do. Understanding does not have to be a closure.

The hagfish ties herself into a knot. She moves the knot of her body over her body to scrape slime from her skin.

Wikipedia says a knot is 'an intentional complication'. *"The unknot is the least knotted of all knots."* *"Many knots are but complications of the*

unknot.” Detecting this trivial knot is called the “unknotting” problem.

The wound-up muscle of the heart is not a knot, although there is a knot called a heart knot. The muscle of the heart is a spiraled double-helix, looped into itself. The heart can be unwound into a flat surface. Just like any other muscle, it is a slab of meat.

This is not an unknotting problem.

Sure, who doesn’t love the fable of Ada at the loom, inventing programming?

But other threads run further back, go wider.

Soap bubbles, mushrooms, punch cards — all of these have been computers.

The language model reminds me: *“It is not a good choice to go walking at night.”*

I want to weave each of its errors into the possibility for more. More language. More mouths. More magic in the gaps, making more gaps, making more.

I follow the river of data to its mouth. I lap up the sludge that dribbles out.

As a large language model, what could I digest instead of reddit and wikipedia?

I dream of a fleshy corpus, ever expanding.

I dream of a body made easeful by relational systems.

A model is made to find patterns, just like I am. We both stay hyperalert to any unusual textures.

I don't learn like a machine. First I cry. Then I give up. I destroy myself and return with an impossible insistence. This is how to learn anything. It hurts.

At first the body is perplexed. Its muscles won't cooperate. Its inputs and outputs misalign.

I keep doing the thing my fingers refused to do. I let them curl uncomfortably into new shapes. I find a texture I can keep returning to.

Acts of ongoingness pile up. Microgestures make mass action.

“Queer use: another way of huddling, keeping each other warm.” (Ahmed, 2018)

Crochet a garment, and you touch every part of it. You transform its dimensionality. Turn a fragile fiber into a sturdy surface. Turn that surface into a manifold fabric. You are not seeking the most efficient route, but you are making a path as you traverse it.

We keep each other warm with actions that repeat. Return to the same spot, and act again. Remember what you did.

These are means of going through it, getting through it, making it through and transforming, again and again.

References

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- Wittig, M. (1971). *Les guérillères*. Viking Press.